H. Parallel Poem

John Magee holds a special place in the hearts of pilots the world over. An American, he joined the Canadian Air Force before the U.S. entered World War II and was killed in flight over Lincolnshire, England. He was 19 years old. He wrote the most famous air force war poem ever written, High Flight. He wrote the poem in the cockpit while flying at 30,000 feet and mailed it to his parents upon landing.

High Flight

John Gillespie Magee, Jr.

Oh, I have slipped the surly bonds of Earth
And danced the skies on laughter-silvered wings;
Sunward I've climbed, and joined the tumbling mirth
Of sun-split clouds – and done a hundred things
You have not dreamed of – wheeled and soared and swung
High in the sunlit silence. Hov'ring there,
I've chased the shouting wind along, and flung
My eager craft through footless halls of air...



Up, up the long, delirious burning blue
I've topped the windswept heights with easy grace
Where never lark, or even eagle - flew.
And, while with silent, lifting mind I've trod
The high untrespassed sanctity of space,
Put out my hand, and touched the face of God.

(Also read the poem Ozymandias by P.B.Shelley.)

06-B-Poem-The Hollow Crown.indd 189 11-12-2021 15:09:40